

OLD GUARD, NEW FIRE

Renato Moicano proves his class while Ewing, McMillen and Pereira signal the arrival of a **fearless** new crop.

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In the main event of UFC Vegas 115, Renato Moicano (**above, left**) didn't just win; he reasserted his relevance in a ruthless lightweight division.

Coming off losses to elite grapplers in Islam Makhachev and Beneil Dariush, Moicano entered his bout against Chris Duncan needing to prove that he remains a top-tier threat. The performance was a masterclass in composure, centred around a crisp, snapping jab that consistently outpaced the hard-hitting Duncan. By dictating the range and rhythm early, Moicano neutralised Duncan's power and systematically broke him down.

Once the opening presented itself in the second round, Moicano transitioned seamlessly to his grappling, securing a rear-naked choke. The fight came to a close in the second minute of the second round as Duncan tapped out.

His post-fight plea for an "easy fight" next was classic Moicano, but his clinical execution suggested he is still very much ready for the division's elite.

The undercard at the Meta APEX was defined by the emergence of a new generation, starting with

light heavyweight prospect Abdul Rakhman Yakhyayev.

Moving to 9-0 with a swift first-round submission of Brendson Ribeiro, Yakhyayev showed incredible fight IQ. After a brief striking exchange where he felt Ribeiro's power, he immediately shifted to his wrestling, proving he has the tactical flexibility to match his physical dominance.

Similarly, Ethyn 'The Professor Finesser' Ewing continued his streak as an enforcer. After taking a short-notice win on his debut, Ewing handed the previously 14-0 Rafael Estevam his first career loss. A vicious body shot in the second round folded Estevam, marking Ewing's second consecutive win over an undefeated opponent and signalling a potential rankings run at bantamweight.

The energy reached a fever pitch during Tommy McMillen's debut, which lived up to the significant hype provided by his teammate, Sean O'Malley.

The bout with Manolo Zecchini was characterised by what his corner called "chaos", earning both men a \$100,000 Fight of the Night bonus.

McMillen ultimately ended the madness with a crushing knee to the body followed by ground strikes.

Not to be outdone, 20-year-old Alice

Pereira finally found the win column in spectacular fashion. Facing Hailey Cowan, Pereira utilised her length before landing a perfectly timed knee that resulted in an instant highlight-reel knockout. Overall, the card served as a pedestal for fighters from different generations.

While Moicano proved that experience and technical fundamentals still rule the day, the explosive finishes from Ewing, McMillen, and Pereira suggest that the next wave of UFC talent is arriving with a frightening level of poise and power.



Did you know?

At just 20 years old, Alice Pereira (left) holds the record for being the youngest female fighter ever signed to the UFC roster.

Her nickname, 'Golden Girl', is a nod to her early start in combat sports. She began training in muay thai and jiu-jitsu as a young child in Brazil.

Pereira, who made her professional MMA debut in 2023, made her maiden UFC appearance in 2025, marking one of the fastest transitions in the modern era of the sport.



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